



GUEST EDITORIAL

Guest editorial

Glass ceilings, glass cliffs or new worlds?

Revisiting gender and accounting

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this paper is to set out some contextual issues in relation to the achievements of women accountants and academics.

Design/methodology/approach – This is a discussion paper that uses academic and professional experiences as a basis from which to draw out an agenda for further study.

Findings – It is found that, despite changes over the last 30 years, the lived experience of women in accounting and academia is evidence that their academic and professional opportunities are still constrained. Two papers in this special issue offer feminist approaches to enrich study in the area, and it is argued that gender is an element that should be embedded in research in accounting.

Research limitations/implications – This editorial is a selective review and is not intended as a comprehensive review of research in the field.

Practical implications – The paper seeks to re-ignite more research in the field, using a richer range of approaches.

Originality/value – The paper sets an agenda for research and provides an argument as to why the agenda needs to be pursued.

Keywords Accountancy, Gender, Sexual discrimination

Paper type General review

The catalyst for this special issue of *Accounting Auditing & Accountability Journal* was our reaction to a conference paper using gender-as-a-variable. This paper purported to show that there was now no gender gap in remuneration, but that differences were the result of the fact that women tended to work in smaller companies where the salaries for men and women alike were less. Our reaction to this was mixed. The paper raised more questions than it answered, not least as to why women are located predominantly in this sector of the economy. Instead of moving forward, this paper suggested we are simply revisiting previous concerns:

The Guest Editors would like to thank the joint editors for arranging the review of this editorial and for their support in developing this special issue. Thanks are also extended to the referees, who have helped to strengthen the arguments presented, and to the Guest Editors, who have worked so hard to provide the range of papers published. Errors, of course, remain the Guest Editors'.



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- (1) Why had we not moved on?
- (2) Why had the ground-breaking work that had appeared in the literature earlier, for example in the special issue of *Accounting Auditing & Accountability Journal* in 1992, not been built on and replicated?
- (3) Why was the matter of gender still seen as a sub-area and not an issue to be integrated into our everyday work?
- (4) How was it that accounting researchers were still able to examine fundamental questions in the discipline without at least asking themselves if and how gender might impact upon both the questions they were asking and the understandings they were seeking?
- (5) How was it that accounting researchers were still able to examine fundamental questions in the discipline without at least asking themselves if and how gender might impact upon both the questions they were asking and the understandings they were seeking?

These lacunae in the literature and an emphasis in the work being undertaken on gender-as-a-variable, led us to pursue this further. This is the reason for this special issue of *Accounting, Auditing & Accountability Journal*.

One aim in this editorial is to connect our own experiences to the broader research perspective in order to try to illustrate why we believe gender remains a substantive issue that should be of concern to the accounting community more generally, and to the accounting academic community more specifically. We also wish to show how our choice of papers illustrates some of the questions and issues noted above. Whilst there are no simple answers to the questions raised, we believe that the papers in this special issue do illustrate and explore ways in which we might approach research and take the agenda forward.

In undertaking this *Accounting, Auditing & Accountability Journal* special issue we have reflected on our own experiences and have focussed on both practice and academia. Whilst these experiences are at one level anecdotal, they nevertheless are our lived experience. It is, at times, impossible to prevent these experiences informing our work because they are key to our understanding of the concept of gender. This is so for everyone, but particularly for women with family responsibilities for whom the term “work-life-balance” is not an academic concept but an everyday experience. In offering our own experiences we are seeking to engage in feminist methodology as advocated by Haynes (2008) in as far as it is “using women’s’ experience” (our own) as well as allowing us to “locate firmly in the research both intellectually and reflexively”.

Reflecting on our own experiences more generally, we should note our view that although the World has, for some women, changed much over the last 30 years, it has, in some ways, stayed the same, and for that reason the issue of gender remains just as relevant as it was then. Commentators might argue to the contrary that Western women have made enormous strides in gaining equality of opportunity. We are supposedly in an age of post-feminism where feminist issues, according to some critics, have been sidelined or trivialised as “political correctness”[1]. Feminism is much less visible than it was in the 1970s and early 1980s. Then feminism was all around us and a range of feminist writers published their work (Greer, 2006; Rossi, 1988; Spender, 1980) and activism such as the Greenham Women’s demonstrations over 20 years

against the siting of short-range nuclear missiles in the UK. Then, the contribution of women to society and the potential for more was discussed and debated. We seemed to be at a watershed, but where has this now taken us? In the post-feminist twenty-first century the popular media celebrate the “girl power”. Prominent women include the Spice Girls and the ubiquitous Wives and Girlfriends (WAGs) of rich sports stars. Their visibility arguably stems from a commodification of their individual bodies. They are, as such, celebrated as princesses of consumerism, using their power as consumers to mould themselves into the image of their childhood Barbie Dolls. In the academic field Faludi (1993) draws together these themes in a scholarly fashion and reflects on the extent to which an anti-feminist backlash has been successful in sidelining feminism in everyday contexts.

Nevertheless, it is counterproductive to deny the legacy of the 1970s women’s movement. Women now succeed in a wide range of activities, for example, educational examinations and assessments. Indeed, girls now achieve better results than boys at many levels in disciplines in which they had not previously been well represented. However, this poses a number of problems for women who go far but still hit a metaphorical “glass ceiling” and thus experience injustices in their ultimate achievement levels. As young women now achieve more success than young men in areas such as university entrance (following better examination success at school) the relevance of feminism can be questioned. What are the prospects for our daughters today and do they want what we wanted, and wanted for them? Are we simply indulging in nostalgia for our own youth by asking questions about the contemporary place of women? Clearly, in undertaking this project, we think the answer is no. We are not alone. The debate about feminism persists and has been the forerunner of a range of academic work celebrating masculinities, sexualities and ethnicities. This signals the complexity of the field more generally and has ensured that the development of ideas continues.

We should nevertheless acknowledge the improvements for women that have been achieved not least in the accounting profession. The progress made by women entering the profession in the last 40 years must not be ignored. In 1970, when Jane was training, it was unusual to see women train to be accountants, not unknown, but unusual – she encountered only two other women in all the five years of part-time study as a trainee accountant. The assumption was that accountants were men. A trivial but telling demonstration of this was when Jane was taking an early set of professional examinations and the special cloakroom in which candidates were expected to leave their coats was in the Gents toilets. Jane, the only woman candidate, had to find somewhere else to leave her coat! In the early 1980s, when Linda was being interviewed for a training contract with a medium-sized firm she was asked if she had a boyfriend and how he would feel about her having to study at nights and weekends. Unsurprisingly, the male candidates being interviewed on the same day were not asked a similar question. During Linda’s training, certain jobs were considered unsuitable for a woman trainee due to the attitudes and/or culture of the clients’ premises, and these were allocated exclusively to (white) males thereby limiting the range of work experience and opportunities for the few women in the office. Questions at job interviews at the time explicitly explored with both Jane and Linda what they thought about entering a male profession – something that would now leave an organisation open to a charge of discrimination. It was the fact that Jane had been told about a

woman who had qualified through the Regional Training Scheme that made her choose to take up the offer of a post with the NHS rather than at Rolls Royce. Nowadays, these issues may be implied rather than openly discussed – if they were, there is legal recourse for those who wish to take up the possibility!

Women have entered the profession despite these attitudes[2] and indeed small numbers of women had been pioneers in accounting practice. Ada Bourn, the aunt of Sir John Bourn, our recently retired UK Comptroller and Auditor General, may have inspired her nephew to his profession. In 1916 she successfully completed the examinations of the London Society of Accountants (the precursor to the Association of Chartered Certified Accountants (ACCA)) at the age of 18 years, although she could not take up membership until she was 21 (Bourn, 1998). This situation is one that has changed considerably. Historic trend figures obtained from the ACCA, for example, show numbers of women members remained small until the early 1970s when they began to increase significantly. The reason for this is a topic worthy of detailed study. Equal numbers of women and men now enter the ACCA as students and the figures show that 40 per cent of new entrants are now women with 22 per cent members overall being women.

This same trend is apparent in all the UK professional bodies and the Professional Oversight Board in Accounting (POBA) report on key facts and trends in the accountancy profession reports that in total 30 per cent of members of Accountancy Professional Bodies are now women (POBA, 2007).

The figures show in detail some variation in the different bodies as follows:

- Association of Chartered Certified Accountants (40 per cent);
- Chartered Institute of Management Accountants (28 per cent);
- Chartered Institute of Public Finance and Accounting (27 per cent);
- Institute of Chartered Accountants in England and Wales (23 per cent);
- Institute of Chartered Accountant in Ireland (31 per cent); and
- Institute of Chartered Accountants of Scotland (26 per cent).

Information obtained from some of these bodies also demonstrates the percentage of women students is growing and this has implications for future membership:

- Association of Chartered Certified Accountants (50 per cent);
- Chartered Institute of Management Accountants (45 per cent);
- Institute of Chartered Accountants in England and Wales (40 per cent); and
- Institute of Chartered Accountants of Scotland (46 per cent).

The differences between the different professional bodies is also worthy of more detailed study.

A general argument – highlighting the trickle down effect – suggests that the changing demographics of the profession provide equality for women in due course. The “Big Four” espouse a commitment to gender diversity and there is some evidence they are seeking to address the issue. PWC has a Gender Advisory Council, Deloitte have a Women’s Initiative in the US (although we could not find the equivalent in the UK), Ernst & Young note their commitment to diversity celebrating their achievements in a range of benchmark awards (Opportunity Now’s Gender Diversity benchmark as

well as Stonewall's listings), the KPMG Annual Report 2007 notes the firm's commitment to diversity and also highlights the women's diversity programme, which is seen as a practical solution to the problem that the 13 per cent proportion of women partners remains static.

However, there is evidence of a gap between women's experiences and the formal efforts of firms to create equality of opportunity. There is as yet no indication that a trickle-down effect will in time ensure more women achieve partnerships and other senior positions. The work of Dambrin and Lambert (2008) provides a qualitative account of the difficulties of managing career progression, particularly in relation to motherhood, an account that echoes the extensive work of Haynes in her PhD thesis (Haynes, 2005). Despite the gains in the general approach to women forged through feminist lobbying and consequent diversity legislation, evidence from the UK (Gammie, 2007) shows that it still remains difficult for women to progress to partnerships and the most senior positions in the profession. Moreover, work in the more general arena of public services shows that whilst some women are able to break through the glass ceiling there is some evidence that they simply make it to a glass cliff. That is to say that when they reach the top they are more likely to lose their jobs when things go wrong, than is the case for their male colleagues (Nutley, 2005).

In summary, our argument is that despite some significant gains there remains a set of issues to address in relation to women's progression in their accounting careers. In 1970 in the UK there is some evidence of a change. In 1970 in the UK accountancy was not the Graduate entry profession that it is today and since then many aspects of the profession and associated training have changed. Increasing growth in women's membership of the profession was only one, albeit significant, element of change. The profession at that stage was at a noteworthy point in its continuing attempts to ensure professional closure (Walker and Shackleton, 1998), historically this has always been an element with implications for women entrants. However, whilst studies of the emergence of the profession have sought to explore the effect of gender on professional closure (Roberts, 1992) and the early foundations of professional formation (Kirkham, 1993) and whilst other scholars have considered the experience of contemporary women (Gammie, 2007; Haynes, 2005), little has yet been done to explore the rich detail of the feminisation of the profession over the past 40 years where the growth in women membership has risen exponentially. Gathering oral histories of those who have lived through this period remains an intriguing possibility. This suggests an interesting PhD project, as does the consideration of the differential membership profiles of the various professional accountancy bodies. International comparisons would also be of interest.

Returning to the theme of exploring our own experiences, we turn next to our own current milieu, the academic world. If we see education as an important driver of social change it should be enlightened in its practices. How well is it progressing in its support of women? A count of women Vice-Chancellors in the UK shows they account for about 9-10 per cent of the population depending on how the count of the institutions is made[3]. This is in line with international comparators. The Association of Commonwealth Universities has taken some care to track women's achievements (Singh, 2002) and, for those whose gender was reported, showed that whilst 22.6 per cent of those employed at Senior Lecturer and above were women, at the level of Vice Chancellors and Presidents women were only 9 per cent of the total population. In 2006,

the snapshot provided by the BAR Register demonstrates a similar disparity and shows that in England, Wales and Scotland approximately 27 per cent of accounting academics were women and approx 10 per cent of the professoriate were women. This again demonstrates the difficulty for women in securing progression and the data suggests that educational institutions at the tertiary level “could do better”.

Our own experience richly illustrates of some of the institutionalised pressures that affect women. An analysis in one HEI[4] of the workload of women and men illustrated the potentially significant nature if this indicator. The ratio of academic women to men in the institution was 30:70. The allocation of significant roles for research related positions and Heads of Department also followed this profile. The allocation for more teaching related and pastoral roles was instead 50:50. This meant that women were taking a relatively larger load of this time intensive work that carried less status in a research intensive institution and which could be seen as less relevant in promotions. This pattern could be investigated to reveal whether women are being institutionally and systematically disadvantaged and/or channelled through their work experience and task allocations. To what extent are women’s employment patterns in academia being subtly influenced, differentiated and devalued by the internal and external employment opportunities which are afforded or denied them, usually implicitly? Our experience suggests that motherhood creates major obstacles for women in academia, not least because institutions have tried to accommodate mothers within their masculine practices and values rather than exploring the need to change those practices and values. Our experience also illustrates that when there is a critical mass of women at senior management levels it is easier to continue to recruit women to such roles. The loss of senior women reducing the critical mass can lead quite quickly to a loss of female representation in senior institutional posts. This alerts us to the fact that gains are not to be taken for granted and that changes may be reversed.

In summary, our experience as women academic accountants suggests that gender must remain a matter for consideration. Our lived experience also confirms that the reasons for women’s advancement as well as for women’s disadvantage are not always simple and are to a great extent institutionalised. There is, of course, little here that is novel in general terms. Extensive studies of these matters have been undertaken that have addressed these problems in more detail than we are able to achieve in this editorial. Nevertheless, in setting out to build this project we had a real sense that if gender is to make a more significant impact on day-to-day accounting and accountants then aspects of the consideration of gender must themselves be institutionalised in everyday practice and thought.

It followed that a number of concerns drove the choice of papers and their nature. We wanted to return to women’s experiences, although we wanted to paint a canvas that is rather broader than the Anglo-centric view that is apparent in the discussion above based on our own experiences. Hence, the first paper in this special issue, by Dambrin and Lambert (2008) looks at the views of those working for the Big Four in France and illustrates the difficulties that motherhood can bring. The arrival of a family provides challenges for men and women, but women cannot disengage from the visible effects of pregnancy. Komori (2008), in the second paper, considers the experience of Japanese women and argues that women have changed accounting practice by applying a feminine approach to their work. Whilst much of that which is reported in the French situation is familiar to those of us raised in an Anglo-centric

environment, the unfamiliarity of the Japanese culture is reflected in Komori's work. This second paper challenges a lot of what we might take for granted and reminds us of the impact of culture on what we find comfortable. Two papers are not enough to cover the complexity that different cultures provide, but they highlight the importance of looking at these issues.

We also wanted to consider research approaches in order to encourage debate and to promote different ways of understanding and extending knowledge. The third paper by Haynes (2008), on the use of feminist methodologies, provides a thorough overview of the various approaches adopted as well as seeking to move the agenda in a constructive fashion. She calls for a distinct feminist approach demonstrating where this might be applied and arguing that this provides the opportunity to radicalise the agenda. It is a call for action in an area of accounting research that has become somewhat conservative. The fourth paper provides an example of a different research approach for understanding gender. Dillard and Reynolds' (2008) paper embraces the challenge to work in different ways that moves beyond simple gender distinctions to new levels of integrated thinking and understanding. As such their work extends familiar boundaries. Again, this reminds us of the constraints of our various cultural assumptions, as members of different nations, as members of the academic academy and as women and men. In providing this challenge the paper perhaps needs to be considered within a collection of other papers that provide the landscape in which we can reflect on the boundaries within which we are used to work.

Finally, we wanted to explore the extent to which gender is embedded (or not) as a taken for granted element in research in accounting more generally. This is provided by two papers from different contexts that demonstrate that consideration of gender remains an exception rather than the rule. In paper five, Walker (2008) provides a commentary on the extent to which historians have engaged with women's issues. Whilst historians have provided some significant advances, by recovering and rescuing histories of women in a general context, Walker argues that accounting historians have not made similar advances. He makes an eloquent case for remedying that omission. In paper six, Parker (2008) has a difficult task in reviewing the extent to which research and practice in strategic management and accounting processes acknowledges gender. In an area where there is little broad tradition of considering gender, the task of reviewing the area was complex and the suggestions for embedding or institutionalising consideration of gender and gendered approaches are, therefore, important. They are important because they point to the possibility of developing different approaches to practice that provide potential. Both these papers therefore present a challenge for all researchers in their areas and indeed beyond and not just for those concerned with gender *per se*. These two authors demonstrate the difficulty of seeking to embed considerations of gender routinely in studies of accounting.

In summary, we have here a diverse but rich set of papers that challenge the reader. They push the boundaries yet also ask us to consider what we are doing within our existing margins of research and practice. Putting together the *Accounting, Auditing & Accountability Journal* special issue has reminded us of the complexity of gender. It has shown that women's position has changed, but that change has stalled at the same time as women have greater success and opportunities up to a "glass ceiling". The extent to which we understand why that is the case remains to be understood. We believe it is important that consideration of gender is not ghettoised as a "women's

matter". It is an inescapable part of the lived experience of both men and women and offers the possibility of providing understanding and practices that will bring benefits to society as a whole. We do not propose any single answer to the question of how consideration of gender might impact for the better, but believe that in considering a wider range of possibilities, resulting solutions will be richer and stronger.

Notes

1. It would not be the same argument in the case of women denied education in some extreme regimes across the globe.
2. Including the two of us!
3. Women are better represented in Colleges of Higher Education and University Associated Colleges; hence it depends which institutions are counted as within the population of Universities.
4. In which one of us worked.

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